Feynman had changed his tune. “He was extremely friendly,” Aspect recalled. “He made interesting comments.” After the talk, Feynman invited Aspect back to his office, where they discussed his work further. Once Aspect returned home, he received a letter from Feynman, following up with further praise: “once again let me say, your talk was excellent.”

Though it’s unlikely that he learned much from Clauser’s ill-fated visit to his office, Feynman was certainly well aware of Bell’s theorem by the time Aspect arrived at Caltech. In the aftermath of the first Bell experiments, there had been a flurry of articles on the subject, explaining Bell’s theorem to both physicists and the public at large. D’Espagnat had written the first popular account of Bell’s work, in *Scientific American* in 1979. Shortly thereafter, popular books on quantum physics published by physicists and writers associated with the Fundamental Fysiks Group in Berkeley, such as *The Tao of Physics* and *Quantum Reality,* covered the subject as well. And a celebrated series of articles on Bell’s theorem by the distinguished Cornell physicist N. David Mermin elucidated the subject for his fellow physicists through a set of particularly simple thought experiments, which rapidly became the standard way of teaching the subject. Feynman, respected among physicists for the clarity of his teaching as well as the depth of his physical insight, was an instant fan of Mermin’s work. “One of the most beautiful papers in physics I know of is yours,” Feynman wrote to Mermin in 1984. “All my mature life I have been trying to distill the strangeness of quantum physics into simpler and simpler circumstances.… I was recently very close to your description when your ideally pristine presentation appeared.”

Feynman himself had explained Bell’s theorem during his keynote speech at a Caltech conference in 1981 (though strangely he did not actually mention Bell himself in the course of doing so). The conference was on a seemingly unrelated subject—the physics of computation—yet Feynman showed that Bell’s theorem held the answer to a crucial question in this field. “Can physics be simulated by a universal computer?” Feynman asked the conference. “[The] physical world is quantum mechanical, and therefore the proper problem is the simulation of quantum physics—which is what I really want to talk about,” he continued. The answer, for a normal computer operating under ordinary conditions, was no: using simple ones and zeros in the usual fashion, without strange long-range connections